

[Return to Search](#)

Veiled sentiments

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Document Type: Book

Original Page: 228

Culture (OWC): [Libyan Bedouin \(MT09\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Northern Africa

Field Date: 1978-1980

Coverage Date: 1978-1980

Place Coverage: Western Desert, Egypt

Section Title(S): Marriage, Divorce, And Polygyny

The same pattern of divergent discourses on love is apparent in the responses of another woman, whose husband took a second wife. Like divorce, polygyny can be a source of anguish for Bedouin women, but concern over loss of the husband's affection is similarly considered culturally inappropriate and personally immodest.

595
[Polygamy](#)

Polygyny among Awlad 'Ali is on the increase thanks to the influx of wealth from smuggling, the skyrocketing value of their traditional lands along the Mediterranean coast, and other economic developments. I gathered from discussions with the older members of the community that in former generations, rather than put up with a co-wife, women were more likely to divorce their husbands or make life so difficult that their husbands would be dissuaded from remarrying. Now other women scold and mollify first wives with such statements as, "Are you the only one this has ever happened to? These days it is to be expected. It happens to everyone." Women joke that only the poor have their husbands to themselves because these men cannot afford second wives. In the community I lived in, over a third of the men married longer than two years had more than one wife. The correlation between wealth and polygyny is clear; only one of these men was not from the wealthy core families.

178
[Sociocultural Trends](#)

439
[External Trade](#)

556
[Accumulation Of Wealth](#)

586
[Termination Of Marriage](#)

595
[Polygamy](#)

Reactions to a husband's second or third marriage vary. In some cases, especially when the senior wife has been consulted or has approved or even chosen the new wife, things go smoothly. People could always point to

595
[Polygamy](#)

examples of households in which co-wives were "like sisters." My community had several such pairs of cooperative co-wives who rarely fought and appeared to be close and inseparable companions. In many other cases, however, women meet the news of their husband's decision to take a second wife with less equanimity, and relations between co-wives are often strained or volatile.

In addition to social pressure against displaying negative responses to the prospect of sharing a husband, internal pressures  229 for comportment in terms of sexual modesty determine many women's public responses in this trying situation. The concern to convey indifference to the loss of the husband's affections underlay the response of one woman whose husband was about to take another wife. One day he accused her of having stolen a tenpound note that was missing from his pocket (he later found the note in another pocket). She was hurt by the false accusation and angry, but rather than going home to her kin in anger, as she might have done under ordinary circumstances, she forced herself to stay. She worried that people would misconstrue her motives and assume that she had left because of the husband's upcoming marriage, not the false accusation. In households where polygyny is already a fact, women often take the offensive, seizing on violations of their rights to validate displeasure. An unhappy wife can always find some infraction on which to hang her complaints, because polygyny is clearly regulated in Bedouin society; the requirement that a husband treat his wives equally, from following a strict nightly rotation to bringing each identical gifts, right down to every bar of soap, opens vast possibilities for grievances.

578

Ingroup Antagonisms

595

Polygamy

834

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